RAMBAM'S LAWS OF REPENTANCE - HILCHOT TESHUVAH

Serving from Love: Why the Torah Promises Rain, Not Olam HaBa

Hilchot Teshuvah Perakim 9–10

Sefer: Mishneh Torah, Hilchot Teshuvah (The Rambam's Laws of Repentance)

Chapters: 9 and 10 (complete: the end of Hilchot Teshuvah)

Shiur: Given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 7 January 2025

These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording.

Introduction: Finishing Hilchot Teshuvah

"Somehow it has evolved that we've been spending Tuesday nights for the last couple of years on the Rambam." Tonight finishes Hilchot Teshuvah. After a week's break, from **21 January** a new series will go systematically through **the letters of the Rambam**: the famous ones (on resurrection, the **Letter to Yemen**, the **essay on martyrdom**) and lesser-known ones (to a convert, to a *dayan*, to a simple Jew). In his books the Rambam wrote within a set framework; "in his letters he was able to be more expressive and write in a more personal way."

The three parts of Hilchot Teshuvah

Part	Chapters	Topic
1	1 to mid-3	What teshuvah is, when and how
2	3–4	Identity: tzaddik, beinoni, rasha; what precludes Olam HaBa; the five categories of impediments
3	5–10	Free will (5–6); the power of teshuvah (7); Olam HaBa and its relationship to Techiyat HaMetim, Gehinnom, Gan Eden and Mashiach (8); **this world's rewards (9); serving from love (10)**

Chapter 9: Primary and Secondary Rewards

The question

Chapter 8 established that the true reward is spiritual and beyond us: the most we taste in this world is **1/60th** of Olam HaBa, which is Shabbat (Berachot 57b). The Sages use 1/60 because it is **batel**: "It's there, but it's not really there," like a sixtieth of non-kosher food in a kosher pot.

"The problem is, our Torah doesn't really seem to say that." The Torah constantly promises physical results: the second paragraph of the **Shema** (love Hashem and I will give rain; turn away and I will stop the rain), and the blessings and curses in **Bechukotai** and **Ki Tavo**.

(Why the righteous seem to suffer and the wicked prosper is "a whole different question. We're not addressing that tonight.")

מאחר שנודע שמתן שכרן של מצוות... היא חיי העולם הבא... והנקמה שנוקמין מן הרשעים... היא הכרת... מהו זה שכתוב בכל התורה כולה: אם תשמעו יגיע לכם כך ואם לא תשמעו יקרה אתכם כך, וכל אותן הדברים בעולם הזה, כגון שובע ורעב, ומלחמה ושלום, ומלכות ושפלות, וישיבת הארץ וגלות, והצלחת מעשה והפסדו...

Since the reward of the mitzvot is the life of the World to Come, and the punishment of the wicked is karet, what is all this in the Torah, "if you listen, you will get this; if not, that will happen," all about this world: plenty and famine, war and peace, sovereignty and subjugation, living in the land and exile, success and failure...?

The answer: all true, but secondary

כל אותן הדברים אמת היו ויהיו... ואף על פי כן אין אותן הטובות הן סוף מתן שכרן של מצוות

All these things are true; they were and will be... Nevertheless those benefits are **not the ultimate reward** of the mitzvot.

הקדוש ברוך הוא נתן לנו תורה זו, עץ חיים היא, וכל העושה כל הכתוב בה ויודעו דעה גמורה נכונה זוכה בה לחיי העולם הבא, ולפי גודל מעשיו וגודל חכמתו הוא זוכה

Hashem gave us this Torah, a tree of life; whoever **does** all that is written in it and **knows** it with complete, correct knowledge merits the World to Come, **according to the greatness of his deeds and the greatness of his wisdom.**

Notice the pair, which runs all through Chapters 9 and 10: doing and knowing. "It's deeds and intellect, you'll see this throughout." Your portion depends on your **moral** identity and your **intellectual** identity.

What the physical promises are for

שאם נעשה אותה בשמחה ובטובת נפש... שיסיר ממנו כל הדברים המונעים אותנו מלעשותה, כגון חולי ומלחמה ורעב... וישפיע לנו כל הטובות המחזיקות את ידינו לעשות התורה, כגון שובע ושלום ורבוי כסף וזהב, כדי שלא נעסוק כל ימינו בדברים שהגוף צריך להן, אלא נשב פנויים ללמוד בחכמה ולעשות המצווה

If we keep it with joy... He will **remove what prevents us**, such as illness, war and famine, and **provide what supports us**, such as plenty, peace and wealth, so that we don't spend all our days on the body's needs but are **free to study wisdom and do mitzvot.**

"People spend their whole life making a living but don't actually live their life."

And the reverse: if we abandon Torah for **הבלי הזמן** (as **וישמן ישורון ויבעט**, "Yeshurun grew fat and kicked"), Hashem removes the good that let us rebel and brings the impediments: illness, debts, pressure. This is **not** the blocking of teshuvah from Chapter 6; "it's just harder."

כי אין מעשה וחשבון ודעת וחכמה בשאול: there is no deed, reckoning, knowledge or wisdom in the grave. "One of the most beautiful verses." The work can only be done here.

Summary of Chapter 9: the Torah's promised blessings are **secondary rewards** that **free us** to build the moral and intellectual identity that is our primary reward, Olam HaBa. The curses are the opposite: obstacles.

Question: why does the Torah emphasise the secondary?

In his **Essay on Resurrection** the Rambam adds: because **that's what motivates people**. Most of us, day to day, think about what's good for me *now*, this week, this year. "How often do we stop to think about our real identity and our real portion of Olam HaBa? Which is why this is so good that we're doing this, for yourselves and for myself."

The Rabbi's analogy: salary and bonuses.

- The **salary** is Olam HaBa, the main reward.

- A valued employee also gets **bonuses**: a company car, a phone, **private health insurance** ("you know you have to wait months or years for an operation on the NHS"). Not because they *are* the reward, but because they make you more effective, and they **motivate you now**.

Mark: "But the wicked prosper"

Mark: won't people see wicked people with health and wealth, and be put off? "A fair point." The Rabbi's answer: what Chapter 9 describes is the system for the **completely righteous**. The Gemara (Berachot) says people with some negatives suffer in this world **to cleanse them for Olam HaBa**, a second system running alongside, with "millions of variables in the calculation." And "blessing" doesn't mean being a multi-millionaire: Rashi on Bechukotai says you eat a little and are satisfied, enough for **peace of mind** to focus on what matters.

Zenut means hedonism

The Rambam's phrase is **שנעסוק בהבלי הזמן, ובאכילה ושתייה וזנות**. *Zenut* is usually translated as promiscuity. But in **Sefer HaMitzvot**, on **ולא תתורו אחרי לבבכם ואחרי עיניכם**, the Rambam says "after your eyes" means *zenut*, and defines it as **the pursuit of physical, carnal pleasure** in general. A participant: "hedonism." "Very good."

> **זנות** - shares a root with **זן/מזון**, to feed and nourish. Hence, **מזונות** (the five grains: wheat, barley, spelt, rye, oats).

- **Rachav הזונה** (Yehoshua 2): some Midrashim say she was not a harlot but an **innkeeper**, one who *feeds* people.

- Nourishing the physical self, in whatever form: that is the life the Rambam warns against.

The Mishnah "whose fruits we eat in this world"

The Mishnah said every morning (**אלו דברים שאדם אוכל פירותיהן בעולם הזה**) implies some mitzvot *are* rewarded in this world. Either the Rambam follows the Gemara's view that **שכר מצוה בהאי עלמא ליכא** (there is no reward in this world), or he would read the Mishnah as **greater secondary reward** for those mitzvot.

Halacha 2: Why we long for Mashiach

ומפני זה נתאוו כל ישראל, נביאיהם וחכמיהם, לימות המשיח, כדי שינוחו ממלכויות שאינן מניחות להן לעסוק בתורה ובמצוות כהוגן

This is why all Israel, its prophets and sages, longed for the days of Mashiach: to be free of the kingdoms that don't let them study Torah and keep mitzvot properly.

"So that we're not going to have the UN and all the other nations trying to take away our focus." In that era:

- **Knowledge and wisdom will abound**, **'כי מלאה הארץ דעה את ה**; war will no longer be taught; "I will remove the heart of stone."

- The **king from David's line** will be **wiser than Shlomo** and **a great prophet, close to Moshe**, though not like Moshe. All nations will come to learn from him.

- **The world continues as normal**; the core is **sovereignty** and peace, so we can sit in our land and study.

- It is for **humanity**, not just Jews: the nations will return to the true faith. Some read this as conversion; the main understanding is that they will live by the **seven Noachide laws**.

- "Silk garments growing on trees," the origin of "money grows on trees": you won't need to go out to work for food, clothing and shelter.

"People think Mashiach, that's it, it's all over. No, absolutely not. Mashiach is just that we're able to focus on developing our moral and intellectual identities."

Free will remains in the days of Mashiach (discussed two or three years ago in *Da'at Tevunot*), otherwise development would be meaningless. But it is "a higher level of free will: not between good and bad, but **between good and excellent**."

Wiser than Shlomo? The verse says Hashem made Shlomo wiser than all before and after him. In the **Moreh Nevuchim** the Rambam explains that means **in his own generation**, not for all time.

Chapter 10: Serving Hashem from Love

"One of the most loving chapters... the most heart-charging chapter in the Rambam." It closes **Sefer HaMada**, the first of the Mishneh Torah's 14 books (Yesodei HaTorah, Deot, Talmud Torah, Avodah Zarah, Teshuvah), and leads into the second book, **Sefer Ahavah**, the Book of *Love*, on the mitzvot of daily devotion. "It bridges the gap."

Halacha 1: Not for reward, not from fear

אל יאמר אדם: הריני עושה מצוות התורה ועוסק בחכמתה כדי שאקבל כל הברכות הכתובות בה או כדי שאזכה לחיי העולם הבא, ואפרוש מן העבירות... כדי שאנצל מן הקללות... או כדי שלא אכרת מחיי העולם הבא. אין ראוי לעבוד את ה' על הדרך הזה, שהעובד על דרך זה הוא עובד מיראה, ואינה מעלת הנביאים ולא מעלת החכמים

Let no one say: I keep the mitzvot and study for the blessings (Chapter 9) or for Olam HaBa (Chapter 8); I avoid sin to escape the curses or karet. That is not the proper way to serve Hashem: it is serving from **fear**, not the level of the prophets or the wise.

ואין עובדין את ה' על דרך זה אלא עמי הארץ והנשים והקטנים, שמחנכין אותן לעבוד מיראה, עד שתרבה דעתן ויעבדו מאהבה. It is not wrong; "it's good to serve Hashem from fear." It is where everyone begins. But "this is a very aspirational chapter".

Yirat haRomemut: a third level?

Some Rishonim (e.g. **Rabbeinu Yonah**) speak of three levels:

Level	Meaning
1. **Fear of punishment**	The bottom level
2. **Love**	Serving simply because you love Him, no ulterior motive
3. **יראת הרוממות**, awe of His exaltedness	A fear that grows *from* the love

The Rabbi's analogy for the third: being in the presence of **the late Queen**. You admire her, and in her presence you are afraid, not of being thrown out of the palace (that's level 1), but from awe at who she is.

The Rambam never uses the term. The closest is in **Yesodei HaTorah 2:2**: contemplating Hashem's works, a person comes to love and longing, and **immediately recoils in fear**, knowing he is a tiny creature. So perhaps he agreed with it.

Halacha 2: Doing the truth because it is true

העובד מאהבה עוסק בתורה ובמצוות והולך בנתיבות החכמה, לא מפני דבר בעולם, ולא מפני יראת הרעה, ולא כדי לירש הטובה, אלא עושה האמת מפני שהוא אמת, וסוף הטובה לבוא בכלל. ומעלה זו היא מעלה גדולה עד מאד, ואין כל חכם זוכה לה, והיא מעלת אברהם אבינו שקראו הקדוש ברוך הוא אוהבו

One who serves from love... does the truth **because it is the truth**, and good comes in the end anyway. This is a very great level, which not every sage attains: the level of Avraham, whom Hashem called **"My beloved."**

Even spiritual reward ("I want a great portion in Olam HaBa") is not the highest motive. But: "just because you can't do it doesn't mean you shouldn't do the mitzvot. Absolutely not."

A story: the etrog with no reward

"I'm not a great fan of Chassidic stories, but this one I like." (Told of the **Baal Shem Tov**, or the **Vilna Gaon**.) In Eastern Europe a community would order **one set of arba minim** months in advance and share it. One year the town got none. A wealthy man in the next town agreed to lend his on one condition: **he** would receive the reward for the mitzvah. The townspeople hesitated to tell the rebbe, who was overjoyed: **"Now, for the first time in my life, I can do a mitzvah knowing I'll get no reward."**

"We trick ourselves... Subconsciously, we know deep down there's a reward." The Rabbi doesn't believe the story happened, since he doesn't believe a mitzvah's reward can be transferred, "but it's a nice idea."

Isn't Rabbi Akiva a better example? He was waiting for the specific mitzvah of **kiddush Hashem**, which can only be fulfilled under that pressure. "A similar idea," but more specific.

Halacha 3: Lovesick

וכיצד היא האהבה הראויה? הוא שיאהב את ה' אהבה גדולה יתירה עזה מאד, עד שתהא נפשו קשורה באהבת ה', ונמצא שוגה בה תמיד, כאלו חולה חולי האהבה, שאין דעתו פנויה מאהבת אותה אשה, והוא שוגה בה תמיד, בין בשבתו בין בקומו, בין בשעה שהוא אוכל ושותה. יתר מזה תהיה אהבת ה' בלב אוהביו... והוא ששלמה אמר דרך משל: כי חולת אהבה אני. וכל שיר השירים משל הוא לעניין זה

What is proper love? To love Hashem so intensely that one's soul is bound to it, constantly absorbed in it, **like someone lovesick** who cannot stop thinking of a woman, sitting, standing, eating, drinking. Even more than that should the love of Hashem be in the hearts of those who love Him... As Shlomo said, "I am lovesick." **All of Shir HaShirim is a parable for this.**

"All these movies with passionate romantic love stories" exist, in a sense, so we can understand what love of Hashem means. "If anyone's ever felt like that about Hashem, I'll bow down to such a person."

Halacha 4: Taught only to select students, so why publicly?

אמרו חכמים הראשונים: שמא תאמר הריני למד תורה בשביל שאהיה עשיר, בשביל שאקרא רבי, בשביל שאקבל שכר לעולם הבא? תלמוד לומר: לאהבה את ה'... במצותיו חפץ מאד, ולא בשכר מצותיו

The great Sages taught this **privately, to select students**. Why? Because of **Antigonos of Socho**, who constantly taught **"don't be like servants who serve for reward."** His students **Tzadok and Baitos** concluded there was no reward and no Olam HaBa, and founded the Sadducees and Boethusians.

So how can the Rambam teach it publicly? **Because he has already laid the foundation in Chapters 8 and 9**: there *is* an Olam HaBa. "I will never tell you this by itself, but I can tell you this as the next step."

Halacha 5: *Lishmah* and *shelo lishmah*

כל העוסק בתורה כדי לקבל שכר או כדי שלא תגיעהו פורענות, הרי זה עוסק שלא לשמה. וכל העוסק בה לא ליראה ולא לקבל שכר, אלא מפני אהבת אדון כל הארץ שציוה בה, הרי זה עוסק בה לשמה. ואמרו חכמים: לעולם יעסוק אדם בתורה ואפילו שלא לשמה, שמתוך שלא לשמה בא לשמה

- **Lishmah:** because Hashem commanded it, not for Olam HaBa, a title, exams, *semichah*, becoming a rav or a dayan.
- **Still study shelo lishmah**: it leads to lishmah.
- **Extended to mitzvot:** the Gemara says it of Torah study; the Rabbi is "almost sure" that **Rav Kafich's edition** of the Rambam ("one of the most precise editions... the one I like to study the Rambam from") reads **בתורה ובמצוות**.

Teaching children (Rambam, Commentary on the Mishnah, Sanhedrin): learn this chapter and I'll give you **a nut** ("that was the sweets in those days"; the Gemara keeps children awake on Seder night with nuts); later, nice clothes and shoes; then money; then **status**, a title and a community. Then, hopefully, the person matures and studies "because this is the right thing to do." Rewards and punishments are not the ultimate, "but it's better than nothing."

Which *shelo lishmah* is bad?

The Gemara also says one who studies shelo lishmah "would be better not created."
Tosafot distinguish:

- *Shelo lishmah* for honour or reward: still worthwhile.

- Studying **לקנתר**, to taunt or catch people out ("I'm going to look it up and come back to you to dispute your ruling"): **corrosive**. Better not to study. The Rabbi thinks the Rambam would agree.

Where the Rambam would *not* agree with Tosafot: Tosafot (citing **"I give this coin to tzedakah so that my son will live, and he is a complete tzaddik"**) say doing a mitzvah for a benefit is fine, and the problem is only if you'll **regret** it when the benefit doesn't come. **The Rambam rejects this outright.** He demands a very pure *lishmah*. Such a person is perhaps a **tzaddik but not a chassid**: "fine, but not the highest level."

Halacha 6: Love comes through knowledge

ואינו אוהב הקדוש ברוך הוא אלא בדעת שידעהו, ועל פי הדעה תהיה האהבה, אם מעט מעט ואם הרבה הרבה. לפיכך צריך האדם ליחד עצמו להבין ולהשכיל בחכמות ותבונות המודיעים לו את קונו

One loves Hashem only through knowing Him; **love is proportional to knowledge**, little or much. So a person must devote himself to understanding the wisdom and disciplines that make his Creator known to him.

- **Sefer HaMitzvot, positive mitzvah 3**: one comes to love Hashem through studying **His Torah and His world**.
- **Moreh Nevuchim**: the **natural sciences** are prerequisites for love of Hashem and for prophecy.
- "When we understand deep concepts in science, it's like: **wow!** Look at the wisdom in the world."
- **How do you get to know an author or philosopher? You study their works.** What did Hashem leave us? **The book and the world.** "By studying the book, the Torah, and by studying the world, a person comes to understand and to love Hashem."

"What a beautiful way to complete Hilchot Teshuvah."

Summary

1. **Chapter 9:** the Torah's physical blessings and curses are **true but secondary**. They remove or add obstacles to building our **deeds and knowledge**, which earn Olam HaBa. Like a company's bonuses, they motivate us now.
2. *Zenut* in the Rambam = **hedonism**, the life of physical nourishment alone.
3. **Mashiach** = this world at peace and sovereign, free to pursue wisdom, for all humanity, with free will choosing "between good and excellent."
4. **Chapter 10:** serving for reward or from fear is legitimate but basic. The ideal is **"doing the truth because it is the truth,"** the level of Avraham, a love like being **lovesick**.
5. It was taught privately because of **Antigonos' students**; the Rambam can teach it after establishing Olam HaBa.
6. **Shelo lishmah leads to lishmah.** Start with "nuts." The Rambam's *lishmah* is purer than Tosafot's.
7. **Love grows from knowledge**: of the Torah and of the world.

Coming Up

- **No shiur next week.**
- **From 21 January 2025:** the new Tuesday-night series on **the letters of the Rambam**, about a year's worth.

"It's been a great journey. We started in Elul, in September, together, and we have now finished it."

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/DWEJKHo3RzE · More shiurim: rabbikada.com